

A painting at a kalamkari exhibition | © Anuradha Sengupta/Flickr

Kalamkari with the colours of nature

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Kalamkari: the traditional art of pen-craft



The word 'kalamkari' is made up of '*kalam*' meaning pen and '*kari*' meaning craftsmanship. It involves hand-painting or block-printing on cotton fabric, using natural dyes.

Origins of Kalamkari



A Kalamkari Painting | © Anuradha Sengupta/Flickr

Kalamkari was practiced by musicians and painters (known as '*chitrakars*'), as they moved from village to village, narrating stories of Hindu mythology and depicting them on fabrics painted on the spot using natural dyes.

It is still practiced today, by several generations of families in Andhra Pradesh.

The 'kalam'



Brush-pens made of bamboo reed and cotton thread | © dsource.in

The elaborate process of making a Kalamkari piece involves up to 23 steps, which include bleaching the fabric, sun-drying, preparing natural dyes and hand painting each small detail.

Artists use a pen or 'kalam' made of bamboo or tamarind twigs and cotton thread, to draw and paint elaborate motifs.



Kalamkari Styles



Kalamkari artist | © Anilbhardwajnoida/Wikimedia Commons

Kalamkari is done in two distinct styles; *Srikalahasti* involves free-hand drawings of scenes from Hindu mythology, using natural dyes. Since each stroke is carefully drawn by an artisan, each piece is unique.

Machilipatnam Kalamkari involves the use of hand-carved blocks, which can be used by several craftsmen and can be passed down for generations. These blocks are used to print motifs onto cotton fabric.



Kalamkari woodblock | © Oomana foundationr/wikimedia Commons

The colours of Kalamkari



Colour is filled in using a bamboo pen on a kalamkari piece | © dsource.in

For the black outlines, an iron black colour solution is prepared using rusted iron filings and cane jaggery. Tamarind stems are burned and turned into charcoal, which is used for creating the initial sketches.

The earthy colours of Kalamkari are extracted from natural sources. Mustard or yellow is obtained from boiled pomegranate peels, red is created from bark of madder, and blue is obtained from indigo.

As the need to create without harming the environment increases, Kalamkari provides a beautiful alternative. Fabrics are painted with colours obtained from natural sources.



Due to its intricate designs and eco-friendliness, Kalamkari has become one of the most widely imitated styles of Indian fabric printing.


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